



Spending sputters as households get pinched

Erosion of purchasing power wrecks budgets, especially among poorest

BY JACLYN PEISER

Although investors cheered the Federal Reserve's recent rate cut and the stock market has kept powering along, the economy is facing growing headwinds on one crucial front — consumer spending.

Americans' long-running spending boom is showing signs of faltering as consumers of all income levels scale back and hold out for discounts, leaving the economy on shaky ground. This shift is most pronounced among lower-income consumers, who are disproportionately vulnerable to rising prices and other economic pressures eroding their purchasing power, industry analysts say.

"U.S. consumer spending is not just softening overall, it's doing so in a fragmented way ... and that's a real problem," said Claire Li, a Moody's vice president of credit strategy. "If the benefits and the pressures are not shared broadly, then we're not looking at a balanced or a healthy state of the U.S. consumer base."

Working-class Americans — already up against waning wage growth and rising housing and electricity costs — are easily burned by any increase in grocery prices and tariff-fueled increases on household staples, apparel and furniture, according to recent Moody's Ratings report. They're increasingly dipping into their savings, racking up more debt, and pulling back on discretionary spending, according to recent government data, analyst reports and retail executives.

Meanwhile, those in the middle- and upper-income tiers are being more strategic about when

SEE SPENDING ON A10

As his wife was dying, he chose to take Trump's blanket buyout offer. His bosses said he was too late.



DAVID BECKER/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

A federal worker's test of faith

When the government's resignation offer arrived, Edward Brandon Beckham had no way of knowing.

He was on leave caring for Mikel, his wife of 21 years, who was dying of colon cancer. Under the terms of Brandon's absence from the federal Bureau of Land Management, he wasn't expected to check his work email.

So Brandon, who goes by his middle name, had to learn from the news that the Trump administration was offering to let federal workers like him resign and get paid through September. In mid-April, he decided to accept.

Now, staring at his computer, Brandon,

BY HANNAH NATANSON
IN PAHRUMP, NEV.

Brandon Beckham prays at his church in Pahrump, Nevada, in April. While caring for his wife, who had cancer, he tried to take the government's early resignation offer three times and was rejected.

45, read that he was too late. The offer had closed three days before.

Brandon looked at Mikel, across the living room in her hospital bed. She was asleep. Surely, he told himself, the new government run by President Donald Trump — the man Brandon voted for — wouldn't penalize him for missing a message. He composed an email to his bosses just after 5 p.m.

"As my wife is continuing in Hospice and I am her continuing caretaker, at this time, I am formally requesting that I be placed on Administrative Leave until a deferred resignation date of Sept. 30, 2025," Brandon

SEE FAITH ON A12

CDC panel criticized on chaotic meetings

EXPERTS PAN WORK OF VACCINE GROUP

Its preparedness, grasp of data are questioned

BY DAVID OVALLE,
RACHEL ROUBEIN
AND LENA H. SUN

The chair of a new panel of federal immunization advisers selected by Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. said Friday that the group's "enormous depth and knowledge about vaccines, about science" should be obvious to anyone listening to them work.

But medical associations and scientific experts who watched the Advisory Committee on Immunization Practices meetings Thursday and Friday panned the panel's performance as the group reversed recommendations for coronavirus shots and a combined measles, mumps, rubella and chicken pox vaccine.

They said the members were unprepared, misunderstood or ignored key data, and highlighted flawed or inconclusive research often trumpeted by vaccine critics.

"It's troubling to see the erosion of the committee's integrity," Sandra Fryhofer, a physician who spent almost 20 years working with the panel as a liaison from the American Medical Association, told the advisers Friday. "We're concerned about how vaccine recommendations are being developed by this new panel. Data is being selectively used to justify specific conclusions rather than considering all of the available evidence."

The panel's recommendations to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention guide medical providers and compel insurers to cover the cost of vaccines.

SEE VACCINES ON A11

High-security Kirk memorial will combine funeral, rally

BY CAT ZAKRZEWSKI,
YVONNE WINGETT SANCHEZ
AND DEREK HAWKINS

PHOENIX — With security on the level of a Super Bowl and a speaker lineup on par with a state funeral, conservative activist Charlie Kirk's service will combine memorial with political rally, requiring an unprecedented level of resources.

President Donald Trump, Vice President JD Vance and five members of the Cabinet will deliver remarks at the event Sunday. The White House will send two government planes of staff. More than 200,000 people have responded online that they wanted tickets to the event at the 63,000-seat State Farm Stadium, and organizers have prepared overflow seating in a nearby arena even as they are unsure how many will turn out.

Law enforcement agencies have prepared extensive security measures to address the risks of a rare gathering with much of the presidential line of succession present inside an NFL stadium. Five hundred to 800 Secret

SEE FUNERAL ON A6

Widow takes torch: Erika Kirk emerges as a vocal public figure. **A7**



EL TAYEB SIDDIG/REUTERS

A family reunites after fleeing El Fashir, Sudan, a city besieged by the RSF paramilitary group.

In Sudanese city, 'death everywhere'

El Fashir's fall in civil war could trigger bloodbath, rights groups say

BY KATHARINE HOURELD
AND HAFIZ HAROUN

For the hundreds of thousands of civilians trapped inside the besieged Sudanese city of El Fashir, suffering waits at every turn. They face death by starvation, disease or bombardment if they stay; those who leave have been kid-

napped, raped and tortured. If the city falls, rights groups warn, it could trigger the largest bloodbath yet in the country's catastrophic civil war.

El Fashir is the last city in the western Darfur region outside the control of the Rapid Support Forces (RSF), a paramilitary that has been battling the Sudanese army since April

2023. Around 11,000 soldiers and allied fighters are now struggling to hold the city, a last refuge for more than a quarter of a million people, many of whom fled massacres and ruined villages in other parts of Darfur.

The city shudders under daily attacks: Witnesses described

SEE SUDAN ON A20

Trump breaks DOJ fire wall, urges Bondi to prosecute foes

Series of posts come after he forced out prosecutor who didn't indict James

BY JEREMY ROEBUCK,
PERRY STEIN
AND SALVADOR RIZZO

President Donald Trump demanded that Attorney General Pam Bondi move swiftly to prosecute several political opponents in a series of extraordinary social media posts Saturday, a breakdown of traditional fire walls that have existed between the White House and Justice Department on prosecutorial discretion.

He urged the prosecutions of New York Attorney General Letitia James (D), former FBI director James B. Comey and Sen. Adam Schiff (D-California), claiming all three were "guilty as hell" and that his supporters were noting "nothing has been done." Comey and James were both investigated but ultimately not charged by the U.S. attorney's office for the Eastern District of Virginia this year. Both have denied any wrongdoing.

"We cant delay any longer, it's killing our reputation and credibility," Trump said in one message to Bondi. "They impeached me twice, and indicted me (5 times!),

OVER NOTHING. JUSTICE MUST BE SERVED, NOW!!!"

Trump's messages were one of his most overt attempts to date to override the traditional restraints on the president's involvement in law enforcement investigations after months of calling for criminal charges against those he perceives as political enemies. It comes a day after he called for the ouster of U.S. attorney for Eastern Virginia, Erik Siebert.

In one of the posts, Trump announced he intends to nominate Lindsey Halligan, a White House adviser and his former personal lawyer, to be the U.S. attorney in a high-profile office based in Virginia.

Halligan, a former Florida insurance lawyer who joined Trump's personal legal team in 2022 and was at his Mar-a-Lago compound when the FBI executed a search warrant in its classified records investigation, is the White House adviser tasked with removing "improper ideology" from the Smithsonian Institution. She has no prior experience as a prosecutor.

"She will be Fair, Smart, and will provide desperately needed, JUSTICE FOR ALL!" Trump said on Truth Social.

Siebert resigned under pressure Friday after eight months as interim leader. It came after he

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To some, "directionless" Nationals have too many hands on the wheel. **B1**

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Why SpaceX, Elon Musk keep winning in space — and with NASA. **B11**



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Softening market may mean a hot fall for D.C.-area home buyers.

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